

ISLANDS OF SKULLS

IN THE PACIFIC OCEAN THAT ARE
VERITABLE GOLGOTHAS.

Not Far From the Pacific Coast, and
a Scientific Party is Now
Exploring Them.

A party of young scientists acting under the auspices of Harvard university, at Cambridge, Mass., and Leland Stanford, Jr., university, at Palo Alto, Cal., are now exploring the Channel Islands, off the coast of California, and they have sent word to the mainland that their archaeological and ethnological discoveries have been so marvelously rich that the expedition will be prolonged several months, says the St. Louis Globe-Democrat. The Channel Islands have long been known among the old-time residents as the Golgotha of the Pacific, for nowhere else in the world are there probably as many human bones and skeletons lying exposed to the elements as in the Channel Islands. There are several spots on San Nicolas island where whole acres of rocks and sandy deserts are thickly strewn with

Nicolas Island where whole boxes of rocks and sandy waste are thickly strewn with human bones. Only a year ago several men came home to Ventura from the island with a barrel of Indian crude implements, and over 200 whitened skulls, which the men said they had picked from among the thousands of skulls. A dozen of these fast-crumbling skulls were sent to the Smithsonian Institution at Washington, and also to Harvard university at Cambridge. The ethnologists at both institutions were immediately interested, and they declared the skulls were those of a race of Indian giants. Harvard university lost no time in sending an expedition to explore the Channel Islands scientifically.

Probably no region in the United States offers greater inducements to students in anthropology and ethnology than these islands. Ten years ago a resident of San Francisco offered to pay the expenses of an expedition of scientists who should spend a summer in exploring San Nicolas and San Clemente islands, and to give the results of their finds to the United States at Berkeley, but there arose such jealousy among the leaders of the proposed expedition that the offer was withdrawn. The Channel Islands constitute California's only archipelago, with the possible exception of the rocky and scanty Farallon islands. They have been objects of romantic legends, curiosity and mystery for two generations or more.

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Notwithstanding that all the islands are within 32 miles of the California shore, they are solitary and unfrequented, and years roll by with visits to them of fewer than 20 people. Each island has its own particular traditions, and each has countless traces of an occupation by thousands of Indians. When Juan Rodriguez Cabrillo, the Portuguese navigator, sailed up the coast of California in 1542; he stopped for a day or two at each of the Channel islands, and his records bear testimony that on the islands of Santa Barbara, Catalina, San Clemente and San Nicholas, there was "a vigorous and lusty race of natives, who thronged the shores of the little bays and headlands," and gazed in wonder at the white-sailed ship of the navigators. Today the islands stand as they did more than 350 years ago, but the natives are only a memory represented by immense quantities of stone implements, barrels of fine wampum and literally cartloads of human bones.

San Nicolas Island, which lies 50 miles off the little city of San Buenaventura, or, as recently called by the modern and easier name, Ventura, is the most interesting of all the Channel islands, from many points of view. As far back as the memory of any person in Southern California runs, hundreds of white skeletons have dotted the valleys and hillside. Strange utensils of serpentine, sandstone and slate are found there among the

arrange elements of serpentine, sandstone and steatite are found there among the human bones, and the island and its inhabitants have a history so curious that it is difficult of comprehension.

In 1835 the Franciscan padres in the Santa Barbara mission, learning that there were but 16 of the strange Indian race then living, determined to rescue them from the island. They went over in a sloop and succeeded, as they thought, in getting all on board. At the last moment an Indian woman returned for her child, and, one of the frequent storms of the Channel Islands springing up, the sloop was driven away. The sloop went on the rocks off Point Concepcion, and all on board were lost.

Sixteen years later, Captain George Nidever and two men went from the coast in a sloop to hunt sea otters off San Nicolas. On landing they, like Crusoe, were astonished to discover human footprints in the sand. They saw no one, however, and a storm compelled them to put to sea. It was two years later that the captain, revolving in his mind the sight of the footprints in the uncanny island, determined to go and discover and bring over the lonely woman of whom he had vaguely heard. Men accompanied him, and at length they saw on the surf-beaten shore a woman, with long, tawny hair, dressed in a queer garb of colored bird skins and scraping with a bone knife the blubber from a seal. They surrounded

bird skins and scripting with a bone knife the blubber from a seal. They surrounded and approached her stealthily. Although suddenly confronted, she did not appear to be in the least afraid, but smiled, and, then, falling on her knees, prayed to the sun. She offered no objections when, by signs, she was made to understand that she was to go with them in the boat.

They reached Santa Barbara across the rough sea, and the first thing the Indian woman saw was Dr. S. L. Shaw, who is still living at the age of 80 years, riding a horse. She had never seen a spectacle like it, and thought the man and horse were one, and she knelt on the shore and offered her devotions to it. Two weeks afterward the last inhabitant of the rock-ribbed, tempest-beaten San Nicholas died from eating food to which she was unaccustomed, and the curtain fell on her race forever. In speaking of that death at a meeting of the Southern California Medical Society the other day, Dr. Walter Lindley said that if the woman could have been spared for a few years a story of one of the strangest races that ever lived in the Southwest and had had no contamination from the whites might have been learned. The woman, known as the "Lone Woman of San Nicholas," has been the subject of a score of romances and poems, and food for a lot of philosophy of the coast.

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San Nicholas is 10 miles long and four miles across at the widest point. Its topography shows a nearly level plateau with an elevation of from 500 to 1000 feet. Two-thirds of the surface is covered with drifting sand, and the remainder grows a species of nutritious grass and moss, on which 1000 sheep find pasture. Several springs have been discovered, but the water is slightly brackish. Of late years the island is rarely visited, except by sheep-shearers and shell-gatherers, who make annual trips in schooners, fishing smacks or Chinese junks. The only safe landing place is at Coral harbor, a pretty cove, formed by two sandstone arms thrust out from the main barrier of the shore. The entrance is only six or seven yards across, and the water within is placid as a lake, and sufficiently deep to float a vessel of 20 tons burden. On the bleak, silvery strip of beach immense white pelicans are to be seen at any season of the year, promonting with stately dignity. On the approach of a dingy they spread their heavy pointed wings and vanish over the rocks. Further up the shore of the beach there is a dilapidated shearing shed and a weather-worn shanty, belonging to the Chinese shell-gatherers, who haunt these cliffs during the late summer and fall.

Nothing more desolate than the general appearance of the island can be imagined. As far as the eye can trace there are barren levels, with innumerable circular depressions, showing where primitive dwell-

inga once stood. Not a vestige remains of the materials used in the constructions of these rancherias. Hundreds of shell mounds are scattered about, and are found to consist of astonishing numbers of mollusks, the bones of every species of fish found in the channel, skeletons of seals, sea elephants, whales, sea otters, the island fox and various aquatic birds. Without question these animals were used for food by the tribes that once thronged the island. There are also numerous canine skeletons, several of which indicate a species of bull terrier. Judging from the immense quantities of dead land mollusks everywhere, there must have been a time when the island supported luxuriant vegetation. Of all this verdure, nothing is seen today but a few stunted horn bushes, and now and then a cactus forlornly reaching its grotesque arms out of the sweeps of sand. An examination of some of the mounds disclosed all sorts of curious utensils, stone cooking pots, water cillas, mortars, pestles, drills, bone needles and fish hooks, shell beads, charm stones, pipes, cups and a few arrowheads, spear points and swords made of bone. The absence of many weapons proves the peaceful attributes of the islanders. Small imitations of boats and fishes carved from crystallized talc and serpentine also show a rudimentary knowledge of the art of sculpture. In many places

time also show a rudimentary knowledge of the art of sculpture. In many places conical piles of small black pebbles contrast oddly with the white sand. In some instances these pebbles were closely packed in abalone shells. No trace is seen of the brush pens, in which the lone woman of San Nicholas for years found her only shelter from the cutting wind and sand. Every foot of this strange island is eloquent of the extinction of an almost unheard of people.

A trip along the west coast of San Nicholas island over a vast extent of shell mounds sets one to wondering how it was possible for a limited population to consume such prodigious numbers of mollusks. In fact, the infinite variety of mollusca on San Nicholas is said by biologists not to be exceeded in any other known region of equal area. The shore line is of coarse sandstone, burrowed by the pounding surf into fantastic alcoves, bridges, columns and caves. Sometimes these savage cuts form rude effigies bearing a surprising likeness to living creatures. One of the most conspicuous is the exact counterpart of the neck, breast and body of a bird with an alert, hooded head. This piece of nature's sculpture must be 40 feet long, and beheld from a distance looks as perfect as if fashioned by man. Going westward from this gnawed, surf-lashed wall, the ground makes a gentle descent to a wide mesa.

showered, bright-lashed man, the ground makes a gentle descent to a wide mesa, terminating in a steep escarpment.

The atmosphere from this elevation is so deliciously clear that the eye can readily distinguish the peak tops of all the channel islands, although several of them are 40 miles away. Immediately at one's feet there stretches away a dreary desert. A singular characteristic of the place were heaps of the bones of whales, their arrangement and packing so systematically correct as to have withstood a century's sweep of winds over this exposed point. Only one human skeleton has ever been found here. All around are casts of roots of trees in the shifting sand, ranging all the way in size from coarse fiber to several inches in diameter. These semi-petrifications are intact, the wind having swept them clean of the loose earth. They yield a metallic ring when tapped with a rock or shell. A still more remarkable feature of this desert is a sparse stone forest, the broken columns or trunks of trees composed of indurated sand.

At the extreme western end of the island there is a colossal precipice 1000 feet in height. Its chasmed and slitted face softened by a luxuriant growth of emerald moss and lichens. The strangest of all the sights on this island is to be seen on the broad plateau south of the Chinese camp at Coral harbor. Here acres of the sand are littered with thousands of disjointed skeletons. Measurements have

the sand are littered with thousands of disjointed skeletons. Measurements have been made by several scientists of the thigh, leg and arm bones, and literally bushels of skulls and other parts of the human frame have been brought to Los Angeles from San Nicolas Island for investigation. A physician recently counted there over 1300 skulls in one locality. Some were almost dropping to pieces from long exposure to the sun and water.

The general opinion is that the physique of the Indian race that swarmed over the island then was much larger than that of any civilized race today; and that some of them must have been 7 feet 8 inches tall. The skulls of this extinct tribe often measure several inches more than some of the large skulls of today. Many skulls found lying about on the island show that their possessors must have suffered death from a club or blunt battle-ax. No one has yet found a skull on San Nicolas that shows marks of a bullet. There are many collar-bones and shoulder-blades broken and crushed, so it is evident that their owners were killed by some blunt instrument like a warclub or bowdior. Scientists say the favorite weapon in warfare with the Aleutian savage tribe a century or more ago was a club or bludgeon, and this fact fits with the stray tradition that the Aleutians came down and completely destroyed the people on the Channel Islands about 1780.
